A440

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The piano had belonged to Ines's mother, and it had not been tuned since the funeral. For two years it sat against the living room wall like a relative nobody wanted to call. When Ines finally sat down and pressed middle C, the note came out tired and slightly wrong, the way her own voice sounded after crying.

She found Theo in the back of a church bulletin. *Piano tuning and minor repair. Thirty years' experience. I come to you.*

He came on a Saturday in a gray cardigan, carrying a canvas bag, a white cane folded under one arm. Ines must have been quiet a beat too long, because he smiled at the door frame somewhere to the left of her face.

"A lot of us were blind, once," he said. "The schools trained us for it. Ears were the one thing nobody could take."

"I wasn't going to ask," she said.

"You were deciding whether to."

He was right, which annoyed her. She showed him to the piano anyway, touching his elbow once to steer him around the coffee table, and then she didn't know what to do with her hands.

He lifted the lid and played a chord, then another, listening with his head tipped, the way her mother used to listen at the door when Ines came home late. "Someone loved this," he said. "The hammers are worn in the middle octaves. That's where people play songs. The top keys are almost new. Nobody here showed off."

"My mother played hymns," Ines said. "And Juan Gabriel when she thought no one was home."

He laughed, and she liked him for it.

Tuning took three hours. He struck a fork against his knee and held it near his ear, then fitted a lever onto each pin and turned it by degrees too small for her to see. He explained without being asked. A string sounding A should vibrate four hundred and

forty times a second. When two strings are almost the same, they argue, and you hear the argument as a wobble. His job was to listen for the arguing and make it stop.

“How do you know when it’s right?” she asked.

“It goes still,” he said. “Two things that were fighting just agree.”

She made coffee she didn’t drink and sat on the arm of the sofa watching his hands. At some point she told him about the funeral, and the casseroles, and how she hadn’t been able to open the piano because her mother’s reading glasses were still sitting on the music stand. He didn’t say he was sorry. He asked, “Do you want me to move them, or leave them where they are?” She said leave them, and he tuned around them for three hours like they were part of the instrument.

He came back in the spring. Pianos drift with the weather, he told her, and humidity was hard on everything. She had started practicing again, badly, and before he opened the lid he asked her to play something. She played half a hymn and stopped.

“You’re angry at someone,” he said.

She had been fighting with her sister about the house. “I’m not.”

“You’re hitting the left hand like it owes you money.”

She laughed so hard she had to sit down.

After that he asked every time. She played, and he told her what he heard. Tired. Distracted. In a hurry to be somewhere else. Once, in October, he listened to her play a slow, clumsy waltz all the way through, and when she finished he was quiet for so long that she turned around on the bench.

“What?” she said.

“Nothing. You just sounded happy. I didn’t want to interrupt it.”

She didn’t tell him she had been thinking about him. That she had started buying the coffee he liked. That she planned her year around the two Saturdays he would come, the way other people planned around holidays. She was forty-three. She had been married once, to a man who loved her loudly and left quietly. She did not trust anything that felt this much like weather.

The next spring she called to schedule and a woman answered. Theo had broken his wrist on the steps outside his building. It would be a while.

That night Ines sat at the piano and pressed A. It was flat, just slightly. She could hear it now. That was the thing nobody warned you about. Once someone teaches you to

hear the arguing, you hear it everywhere.

She drove to his apartment with a bag of the coffee and no plan. He opened the door with a cast up to his elbow and stood very still, his face turned to the side the way it did when he was listening.

“Ines,” he said, before she spoke.

“How did you know?”

“You walk like you’re apologizing to the floor.”

She laughed, and then, to her horror, she cried. He waited. When she was done, he asked her to come in, and she did.

That summer he taught her to tune. Not the whole piano. Just one string, the A above middle C, the one everything else is measured against. He sat beside her on the bench with his good hand over hers on the lever and told her when to turn and when to stop. She listened to the wobble slow down, slower, slower, a heartbeat settling.

“There,” he said. “Hear it?”

The two strings sounded together and the arguing stopped. The note went still.

She didn’t fall for him. She would think about that later. Falling was something that happened to you on a staircase. This was different. This was turning the lever a little at a time, listening, choosing to keep going until two things that had been fighting finally agreed.

She left her mother’s glasses on the music stand. Theo never asked her to move them.

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